



Samsung BD Writer SH-B022A Ahead Of Its Time?

We got to review Samsung's new Blu-ray writer, the SH-B022A. It writes the largest-capacity on discs that *Digit* has seen thus far—50 GB Blu-ray discs! You can back up your entire hard drive with just a handful of discs.

The drive looks like an ordinary IDE optical drive with the BD marking on the bezel being the only differentiator. Build quality is average compared to the drives we have tested thus far, but the tray mechanism seems smoother, and is quite

RATINGS	
Performance	★★★★●
Features	★★★★●
Build Quality	★★★★●
Value for Money	★★★★●
Overall	★★★★●

noiseless. Going well with "Blu-ray" is the blue LED that glows behind the Eject button.

Blu-ray burning speed is 2x (8.78 MB/sec), a tad faster than 6x DVD (8.1 MB/sec). This doesn't sound too good, since the much faster 16x (21.6 MB/sec) DVD writing is common today. Burning 25 GB to a 2x BD-RE (Blu-ray Disc Recordable Erasable) disc took us 47 minutes—agonisingly slow. But yes, the technology is still being improved, and given a few months, we'll see faster Blu-ray drives.

Backward compatibility has been taken care of, with support for writing to CD as well as DVD recordable media of all kinds—except DVD-RAM. The 8 MB buffer is sufficient to preclude buffer

underruns. Sequential DVD-R burning took 505 seconds, while burning to a DVD+R took more than 8 minutes, both at 12x. This is slower than today's DVD-Writers, which get the same job done in not more than 360 seconds.

The drive comes bundled with CyberLink BD Solution, a software suite for burning as well as video editing, playback, and backup software. Sadly, the suite lags behind Nero by miles.

Ultimately, the price takes the fun out of everything: an obscenely high Rs 22,000, keeping it

out of reach of most of us. Also, A 25 GB disc is about Rs 1,500, and they

aren't easily available. But then, remember that DVD-Writers were priced at \$1,500 in the early 2000s!

Specifications

Reading: BD-ROM, BD-R, BD-RE: 2x; DVD+R, DVD-R, DVD-ROM: 12x; CD-R, CD-ROM: 40x. Writing: BD-R, BD-RE: 2x; DVD+R, DVD-R: 12x; DVD+R DL, DVD-R DL: 4x; DVD+RW, DVD-RW: 4x; CD-R: 32x; CD-RW: 24x. Buffer: 8 MB; interface: IDE

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Price: Rs 22,000



Transcend T.sonic 630 Feature-rich

The T.sonic 630 is trendy-looking and small enough to carry around. It is being targeted at college students on the lookout for a feature-rich music player. It is available in three flavours—1 GB in orchid, 2 GB in pod white, and 4 GB in black. The bright white four-line OLED display is clearly readable in diverse lighting conditions.

The menu is simple to navigate, but the keys have a hard tactile feel. There are six inbuilt equaliser profiles and a five-band customisable equaliser. The player supports one-touch recording, which is one-touch even when the power is off. WAV recording can be from three sources—radio, microphone, and line-in, and the recordings are automatically stored in

three different folders.

Recorded files are named in month / date order. Two recording environments are provided, meeting and memo; the former is more sensitive. The voice activation detection works well only in silent surroundings, and allows for gapless recording.

Playback quality is definitely not the best in its class. The earphones have good overall response, but bass lacks depth. The FM tuner stores up to 20 stations. The player does

not require proprietary software to load songs: simply drag and drop. It supports USB 2.0, but in our tests, it took five minutes to transfer 600 MB of data—very slow.

There's bundled utility software as well: the boot-up

function makes the music player USB-

bootable, and the PC-lock makes the player an access key to your

computer. The partitioning function allows creation of a partition with password protection. The recovery function allows you to reset the player to factory settings.

The 2 GB white model retails at Rs 4,500. Though the player lacks great playback quality, it's good enough for the price.

Specifications

Size: 73 x 33 x 12.5 mm (L x W x H); weight: 30 gm; compression rate: 32 Kbps—320 Kbps; supported music formats: MP3, WMA, WMA DRM -10; charging and data transfer: USB mini port; 15 hrs playback when fully-charged

RATINGS	
Performance	★★★★●
Features	★★★★●
Build Quality	★★★★●
Value for Money	★★★★●
Overall	★★★★●

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Price: Rs 4,500

